As if the team play wasn't good enough, Luis Figo scored an impossible goal early on to give Real the lead. He was about 25 yards out, on the left wing, maybe fifteen yards short of the byeline. I remember looking over and thinking:

'That's a good position for a cross.'

But a cross wasn't what Figo had in mind. He took a little pass from Zidane, checked back and then hit it right-footed, all power and swerve, over Fabien Barthez and in under the bar at the far post. You're happy if you've got one or two players who'll do something like that for you: Real have got half a dozen. I know the manager rates Raul as the best center-forward in the world: Ruud van Nistelrooy would probably get sixty goals in a season playing alongside him. At the Bernabeu, Raul scored either side of half-time. We looked shot to pieces.

But United don't lie down for anybody. That's the boss; that's Keano and that's anybody who wants to play for the club. I talked to people afterwards who were watching on television. They said that, at 3–0, it looked like it was going to be 7 or 8 the way Madrid were playing. But we kept getting our tackles in when we could; kept trying to pass the ball when we had it and, eventually, we got our goal. Ruud deserved it: when we'd been under pressure, he'd been playing their back four on his own. At 3–1, with an away goal, we had half a chance. Right at the end, I missed one that would have made it 3–2. That really would have given us something to chase at Old Trafford. When the game ended, I was looking down at the field, catching my breath and putting a hand to the back of my leg, which was starting to tighten up. Out of the corner of my eye, I saw Roberto Carlos coming towards me. He was smiling. I straightened up and looked at him. Now, he was laughing. I didn't have a clue what about. There was something a little crazy about the moment. I didn't know what to say or do. I smiled back as we shook hands. I could hear the camera shutters clicking and I remember thinking: *That won't make a very good picture back in Manchester.*

The manager didn't say much afterwards. We'd all had enough nights in Europe together to have a pretty good idea what had gone wrong. There was no need for him to lay into us. What mattered was that we get ourselves up for the second leg.

Paul Scholes and Gary Neville were pretty low. They'd both got yellow cards and were going to be suspended for the game in Manchester. I felt bad for Scholesy. He'd missed out on the European Cup Final at the Nou Camp in